

Alessandro Del Piero, though they joined the league well past their prime to help boost its popularity.

Recently, players with more current international exposure have joined the ISL, such as Joni Kauko, who won the UEFA Nations League C with Finland while playing for Mohun Bagan Super Giant, or Jason Cummings (Australia), who joined the same team after playing in the FIFA World Cup 2022.

However, the opposite has rarely happened, and just twice during the ISL era.

Sunil Chhetri, India's all-time top scorer and the highest scorer in the league, played for Kansas City in Major League Soccer in 2010, while Gurpreet Singh Sandhu made just 11 appearances for Stabaek between 2014 and 2017.

Sandesh Jhingan, after moving to Croatian first-division side HNK Sibenik in 2021, failed to find any game time before returning to India.

In the ISL era, FC Goa's current player Jay Gupta developed at the now-defunct FC Pune City before moving to Portugal in 2019, where he played for the reserve sides of GDS Cascais and G.D. Estoril Praia, followed by a brief stint with Spanish side Ebre Escola Esportiva.

In all four cases, the movement was to Europe instead of Asia — a move that eventually saw them return after limited or no game time.

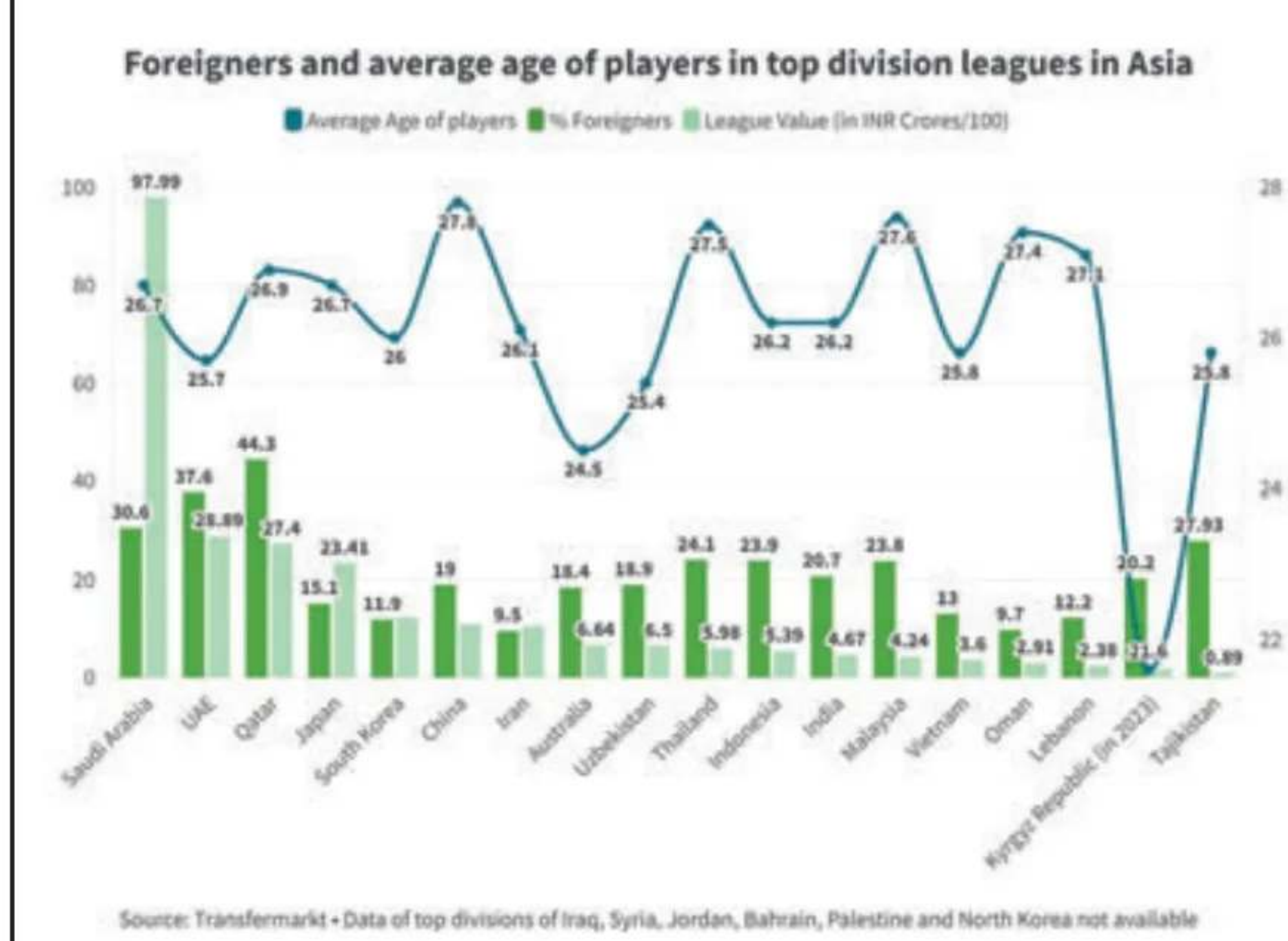
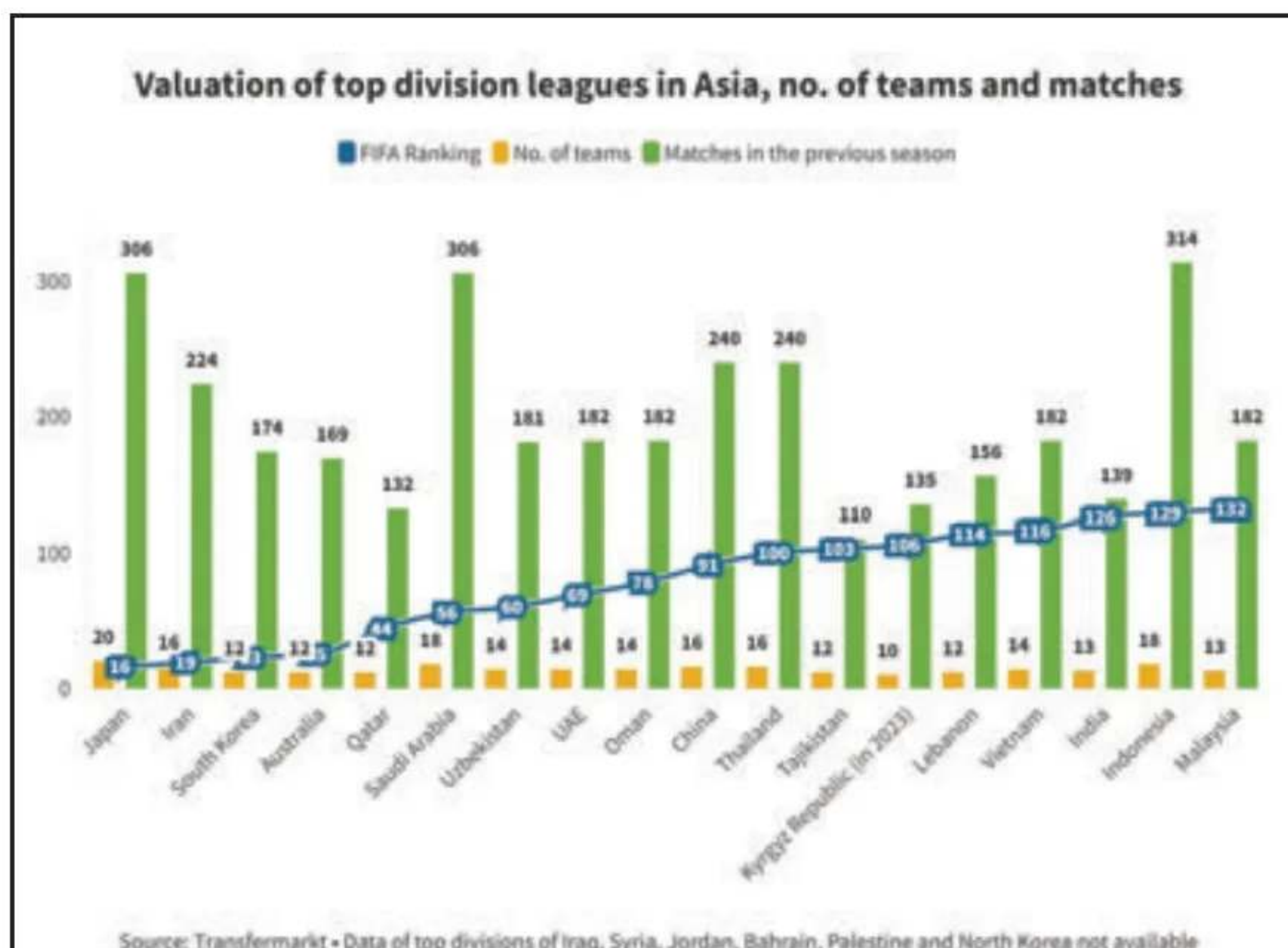
"My feeling is that Indian players are very comfortable. Life is very good for them in the ISL, and it is difficult for them to try and go abroad," Marquez said in his first press conference as India coach.

"You grow when you play abroad. I'm not talking about the top level, like the Premier League or La Liga. But if you go abroad and play against opponents who are better than you, you will improve."

The Japan effect

Japan, the highest-ranked Asian country in FIFA, has been a trailblazer in football league management and youth development.

Its 100-year plan, initiated in 1992, has yielded results both on and off the field, with Asian countries such as



Vietnam and Thailand fully embracing the Japanese philosophy.

Thailand has seen some of its national team players — Supachok Sarachat, Sarach Yooyen, and Ekanit Panya — ply their trade in Japan, while some Japanese coaches have taken up jobs in Thailand's top division.

J1 League side Kashima Antlers' former head coach Masatada Ishii currently manages the Thai national team and helped it secure a knockout spot at the AFC Asian Cup in Qatar earlier this year.

Ishii was previously the head coach of Buriram United, while Makoto Teguramori is the other Japanese coach in the league, in charge of BG Pathum United.

Financially, Thai League 1 is better off than the ISL, valued at INR 598 crores.

Vietnam, on the other hand, has set an example by learning from Asian leaders, Japan and South Korea, despite having a league valued lower than the ISL.

In the last six years, its under-23 side finished as runner-up in the